

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN NORTH MACEDONIA

Complete Community Opposition How-To

This guide is built around North Macedonia's distinctive lever — following a project's money to its international financiers and holding those banks to their own environmental rules — and it names the bodies and tools you'll meet (the EIA and public hearing, protected-area status, the development banks and their complaint mechanisms, the Bern Convention, the courts) in plain words the first time.

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

In the west of North Macedonia lies **Mavrovo**, the country's oldest and largest national park, and one of the last homes of the critically endangered **Balkan lynx** — a wild cat so rare that only a few dozen survive. When the government planned two large hydropower dams inside the park, **Boškov Most** and **Lukovo Pole**, the projects depended on loans from two international development banks: the **World Bank** and the **European Bank for Reconstruction and Development (EBRD)**. A small Macedonian organisation and its allies saw the weakness in that dependence and struck at it. They did not only protest. They held the banks to their **own written environmental rules** — filing complaints to the banks' **own accountability mechanisms** and proving the banks had broken their own biodiversity policies. They invoked an international wildlife treaty, the **Bern Convention**, whose committee called for construction to stop. They rallied scientists, a court, and the public around the lynx and the park. And it worked: in **2015 the World Bank withdrew its funding**, and in **2017 the EBRD cancelled its loan** — and without the international money, the dams could not be built. A national park, and a nearly-extinct wild cat, were saved by a campaign that followed the money.

The small Macedonian organisation that saved Mavrovo followed the money — and the tools it used are available to communities across North Macedonia. A project needs an **EIA** with a **public hearing** and comment. **Protected-area status** — a national park — constrains it. Where a project relies on the **development banks**, their **safeguard policies and complaint mechanisms** are a powerful lever: holding the World Bank and the EBRD to their own biodiversity rules is what cut the dams' funding. International treaties like the **Bern Convention** protect habitats and species — its committee called for construction to stop. The **courts** and the country's **Aarhus** rights on information and participation are open; protest, petition, and litigation are lawful. And as an EU-candidate country, EU environmental standards increasingly apply. But these tools have real limits, and this guide states them plainly. Cutting off the financing **did not, by itself, wipe the projects from the books** — for a time they lingered in official strategy, formally alive though practically dead, and the park still faced other, smaller schemes and a lingering question over its legal status. The strategy leaned heavily on **international leverage**, which works when a project depends on international money and falls under international rules, but not every project does. And it took a **long, patient, expert campaign**, not a quick protest. So follow the money — but be ready to press on past the financiers' withdrawal to secure the formal cancellation, and to guard against the threats that remain.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

A big project looks unstoppable, but it's a chain of dependencies, and a chain breaks at its weakest link. A large Macedonian project needs its **EIA and permit**; if it's in a **protected area** or harms a protected species, it runs into hard rules; and — crucially — if it depends on **international financing**, it is bound by the banks' **own safeguard policies**, enforceable through their complaint mechanisms, and by **treaties** like the Bern Convention. The financing is often the weakest link. **Find the one closest to your hand and pull — and follow the money.**

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Before you spend a year on this, work out your real situation:

- **If it depends on international financing, that is your sharpest lever** — hold the banks to their own rules through their complaint mechanisms.
- **If it's in a national park or harms a protected species, protected-area status and the Bern Convention genuinely bite.**
- **If the EIA or hearing was defective, the courts and Aarhus rights are real grounds.**
- **If it's funded domestically and touches no international rule, the financing lever won't reach it** — lean on the EIA, the courts, protected-area status, and the public, and know it's a harder, longer fight.

Read the whole guide once before you move. Two habits run through it: **follow the money to the international financiers, and use their own rules against them** — the Mavrovo template — and **run every front at once**: the documents, the hearing, the banks, the treaties, the courts, the public. That's how Mavrovo was saved.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

To break the chain you have to see it — who decides, how a project moves, and who's watching.

Who Actually Decides

The domestic decision is the **EIA approval and permit** from the environment ministry, after a **public hearing** and comment. Sector bodies grant the energy or construction rights. **Protected-area status** (national parks and other designations) constrains what may be permitted. But for a large project the decisive actors are often the **international financiers** — the World Bank, the EBRD, and others — whose loans are conditioned on their **own environmental and social safeguard policies**, and whose **accountability mechanisms** can be triggered by an affected community. International treaties like the **Bern Convention** add a further layer of protection. Know which of these you can reach — and follow the money.

How a Project Moves — and Where You Jump In

The EIA and hearing. The developer prepares the EIA; there's a public hearing. *Your opening*: take part, put your objections on the record, and attack the EIA's flaws.

The financing. The project seeks loans from development banks, bound by their safeguards. *Your opening — the decisive one*: file a complaint to the banks' accountability mechanisms, proving the project breaks the banks' own rules.

The protected-area and species status. *Your opening*: invoke the national-park status and the Bern Convention against a project that harms the park or a protected species.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Dig up three things — money first. **Who's financing it** — trace every loan and grant to the international banks and funds, because that is your weakest link. **What rules that money carries** — the banks' safeguard policies on biodiversity, protected areas, assessment, and consultation, which the project may break. **What protected status and species it touches** — because the national park and the Bern Convention are hard levers.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

Each is an ally or an arena. The **environment ministry** runs the EIA. The **development banks' accountability mechanisms** review whether the banks kept their own rules — and can force them to withdraw. The **Bern Convention** committee can call for a halt. **Protected-area status** is a shield. The **courts** and **Aarhus** rights protect information and participation. And North Macedonia's **environmental organisations (like the one that led Mavrovo)**, **international finance-watchdog and conservation networks, scientists, and press** are the forces that reach furthest.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Size up the odds honestly. These are rough patterns, not promises. What most moves them: whether the project depends on international money bound by rules it breaks, whether a park or protected species is engaged, and how determined the government is.

What you do	Roughly works	How long	Cost	What "works" means
Just gather documents	5–10%	weeks	low	The base for everything else
Objections at the EIA public hearing	15–35%	during EIA	low	On record; conditions or a redo
Complaint to a bank's accountability mechanism	35–60%	months–2 yr	low	Bank found in breach; funding withdrawn
Invoke the Bern Convention	30–55%	months–yr	low	Treaty body calls for a halt
Protected-area status lever	30–55%	varies	low–mod	Project barred where the park is engaged
Court challenge / Aarhus	25–50%	months–2 yr	mod	Permit quashed; information forced out
International attention (finance + conservation)	35–60%	months–yr	low	Financiers pull out; project collapses
Everything together (bank-financed, park, protected species)	45–65%	1–3 yr	mod	Financing cut; project dead
Everything together (domestically funded)	20–45%	1–3 yr	mod	Delayed; conditioned; exposed

The lever that moves the needle most is the **complaint to the banks' accountability mechanisms**, backed by the **Bern Convention**, protected-area status, and international attention. Mavrovo shows the ceiling (two great dams killed by cutting the money) and the honest floor (the plans lingered on paper, other threats remained, and it took years). So follow the money — and press on to formal cancellation and against the remaining threats.

On cost: the hearing, the complaints, and organising are cheap; the banks' accountability mechanisms and the Bern Convention are free to invoke, and international watchdog networks bring the expertise. The great strength is that the financing is often the weakest link — and the great requirement is the patience and precision to work it.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Being against "the project" is weak. Being specific — this loan, this broken safeguard, this protected species — is strong. Answer five questions in writing, money first.

1. What is it, and who's financing it? Name the project, the company — and above all trace **every loan and grant to the international banks and funds**. The financing is your weakest link.

2. Where is it, and what does it touch? Map it over **national parks and protected areas**, rivers, forests, and **protected species** (like the Balkan lynx). **A national park and a protected species are hard levers**, and they engage the banks' biodiversity rules and the Bern Convention.

3. What rules does its money carry? Identify the banks' **safeguard policies** on biodiversity, protected areas, assessment, and consultation — and where the project breaks them.

4. What stage is it at, and what's the next deadline? Is the EIA in hearing? Is financing being sought or disbursed (the window to complain)? Has the permit issued? These openings are time-bound.

5. Who else is affected, and who already opposes it? Neighbouring communities, environmental organisations, international finance and conservation networks, scientists. Mavrovo bound a small local group to international expertise.

What this looks like in real life. A community learns a dam or mine, funded by a development bank, threatens a national park and a protected species. The five questions yield: a company and its international financiers (the weak link); a park and a protected species at stake (the hard levers); the banks' safeguard rules it breaks; an EIA or a loan in process; and a coalition of locals and international networks. That's the Mavrovo pattern — follow the money, and hold the banks to their rules.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION

The difference between a community that can fight and one that can't is proof — and at Mavrovo the decisive proof was that the bank had broken its own rules. Build it in three layers.

Layer one: the money and its rules. Trace the **financing** — every loan and grant, from which bank or fund — and get the banks' **safeguard policies**. Then document where the project **breaks those rules**: an inadequate biodiversity assessment, a protected area harmed, consultation skipped. This is your sharpest weapon.

Layer two: the paper trail and the science. Get the EIA, the permit, the protected-area status, and the evidence on the **protected species** and the park. Read the EIA for flaws. Marshal the science on what would be lost — as Mavrovo marshalled the lynx experts.

Layer three: the map of park, species, and harm. Lay the project over the national park, the species' habitat, and the rivers, so the harm — and the breach of the banks' biodiversity rules — is undeniable. Walking into a bank's accountability mechanism, the Bern Convention, or a court with the safeguard breach documented and the science in hand is what makes them act.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

- **The financing** — every loan and grant traced to the international banks and funds.
- **The banks' safeguard policies** — and the specific rules the project breaks.
- **The EIA, permit, protected-area status, and species evidence** — from the ministry and the science; use Aarhus/information rights for the rest.
- **The park-species-harm map** — the national park, the species' habitat, and rivers, laid over the project.
- **Dated site evidence, science, and testimony** — photographs marked with date and place, expert findings, and residents' statements.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Documents give you a case; a coalition that binds local roots to international expertise gives you power — the Mavrovo template. Build in four moves.

Start with a tight core. The people who know the park and rivers, a few tireless organisers, and respected local figures.

Bind local roots to international expertise. Mavrovo worked because a small Macedonian organisation joined **international finance-watchdog and conservation networks** that knew the banks' rules from the inside. Reach those networks — they are how you turn a local fight into a case the banks and treaties must answer.

Rally the scientists and the public around the species and the park. A protected species and a beloved national park give the campaign a clear, unifying cause — the Balkan lynx became the face of Mavrovo. Gather the scientists; rally the public.

Build to last. Mavrovo took years of patient, expert work. Build clear roles, a secure shared archive, a way to decide together, and a plan for the financial and emotional toll — and the persistence to press on past a financier's withdrawal to formal cancellation.

STEP 4: LEGAL & FINANCIAL CHALLENGES

North Macedonia's sharpest lever is not only the courts but the financiers — and their own rules.

Follow the Money and Complain to the Banks

The decisive Mavrovo move: where a project depends on a **development bank**, file a **complaint to the bank's accountability mechanism**, proving the project breaks the bank's **own safeguard policies** — on biodiversity, protected areas, assessment, or consultation. An independent review that finds the bank broke its rules can force it to **withdraw**, and without the money the project falls. This is the distinctive craft of a Macedonian campaign, and it rewards precision — quote the exact policy and the exact breach.

The Bern Convention and Protected-Area Status

Invoke the **Bern Convention** — the European wildlife treaty — whose committee can call for construction to stop where a protected species (like the lynx) is threatened; and lean on **national-park and protected-area status**, which constrains what may lawfully be permitted. Together these are hard levers that also strengthen the case to the banks.

The EIA, the Courts, and Aarhus

Take part in the **EIA hearing** and attack its flaws; challenge a defective permit in the **courts**; and use **Aarhus** rights to force out information and secure participation. These domestic tools support and are supported by the financing and treaty levers.

The Honest Limits

Straight talk: cutting off the financing is often the decisive blow, but rarely the last — the plans can linger on paper, other threats remain, and the strategy needs a project that depends on international money and rules. So use the strong tools — the bank complaints, the Bern Convention, protected-area status, the EIA and courts — pair them with the coalition and international attention, press on to formal cancellation, and count financing cut, a project killed, a permit quashed, delay, and exposure as wins.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

A stack of documents wins nothing until you aim it.

A broken safeguard becomes a bank complaint. Not "we oppose the dam" but *"this project breaks your bank's own biodiversity policy — here is the policy, here is the breach, and your accountability mechanism must act."*

A protected species becomes a treaty case. *"This threatens the Balkan lynx, a species the Bern Convention protects — the treaty body should call for a halt."*

A national park becomes a legal bar. *"This is inside our oldest national park — the law already protects it."*

The harm becomes a global story. *"Two great dams in a national park, drowning the last home of a wild cat down to its final few dozen."*

Match it to the venue: the safeguard breach to the banks' accountability mechanisms; the species to the Bern Convention; the park to the courts and protected-area law; the flaws to the EIA hearing; the global story to the international press and conservation networks.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

In North Macedonia, international attention is the decisive lever, because it reaches the financiers and the treaty bodies beyond the government's control. Conservation and finance-watchdog networks make the media front reach far.

Lead with the park and the species, not procedure. Not "the EIA was deficient" but "two great dams in our oldest national park, drowning the last home of the Balkan lynx." Use your strongest material: the safeguard breach, the science, dated photographs, the map, and any bank or treaty finding banked.

Work several audiences at once — reach the financiers. Local and national press build domestic pressure; international conservation and finance-watchdog networks reach the banks' boards, the treaty bodies, and the world, where the project is most exposed. Make it easy: captioned photos, accurate summaries, a map, strong interviews.

Two hard rules. Accuracy above all — one exaggeration can discredit everything, and precision is the craft here. And protect people — let the coalition shape the story.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Make them your own; keep them short, exact and calm; keep a copy of everything.

8A — Information request (to the ministry / bank).

Subject: Information request — [project].

"Under our Aarhus information rights, we, residents of [place], request the EIA, the permit, the protected-area status, and the financing details for [project] at [location]. [Contact.]"

8B — Objection at the EIA public hearing.

Subject: Objection — EIA for [project].

"We, residents of [place], object to [project]: [it damages our national park; it harms a protected species; the EIA understates the harm]. We ask that it be refused. [Attach evidence.]"

8C — Complaint to a bank's accountability mechanism.

Subject: Complaint — [project] breaches [Bank]'s safeguard policies.

"We, an affected community at [location], file this complaint: [project], which your bank finances, breaks your [biodiversity / protected-area / consultation] policy: [the exact policy, the exact breach]. We ask your accountability mechanism to review it. [Attach evidence.]"

8D — To the Bern Convention (protected species).

Subject: Threat to [protected species] — [project].

"We report that [project] at [location] threatens [the Balkan lynx / protected species], contrary to the Bern Convention. We ask the committee to call for construction to stop. [Attach evidence.]"

8E — To an environmental organisation / international network.

Subject: Bank-financed project threatening [park] — [project].

"Our community faces [project] in [the national park], financed by [bank], breaking its safeguards and threatening [a protected species]. We ask for your help to follow the money and hold the bank to its rules, as at Mavrovo. [Contact and evidence summary.]"

8F — Court challenge (to a lawyer).

Subject: Challenge — [project] permit.

"We instruct you to challenge the permit for [project] and to secure our Aarhus rights, on the grounds that [it damages a protected area / the EIA was defective / information was withheld]. [Attach the decision and our evidence.]"

8G — Letter to the (international) press.

Subject: [Community] acts to protect [national park] from [project].

"For generations [this park] has been [our home / the lynx's refuge]. Now [project], funded by [bank], threatens it. We can provide the safeguard breach, the science, photographs, a map and interviews. [Contact.]"

8H — Rallying the coalition.

Subject: We can save our park — here's how.

"[Project] threatens [our park / the lynx]. At Mavrovo, a small group followed the money, held the banks to their own rules, and killed two great dams. With the bank complaints, the Bern Convention, and international attention behind us, we have a real chance. Please join us. [Contact.]"

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

If you must move fast and lean, do these six things, in order:

1. **Trace the financing to the international banks and funds — money first.** That's your weakest link.
2. **Get the banks' safeguard policies and document where the project breaks them.**
3. **File a complaint to the bank's accountability mechanism (8C), and invoke the Bern Convention (8D).**
4. **Object at the EIA hearing (8B), and photograph everything with dates and places.**
5. **Reach an international finance-watchdog / conservation network (8E).**
6. **Rally scientists and the public around the park and species, and go international (8G/8H).**

Even lean, those six follow the money and use the banks' own rules — the Mavrovo template.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

North Macedonia's tools are real, but the field can be tilted, and you must plan for it.

When the government is determined. A determined government can override local protest — so don't fight only where it's strongest. Follow the money to the financiers, where the government's power doesn't reach.

When the win doesn't formally cancel the project. Mavrovo's plans lingered on paper after the money was cut. Press on to formal cancellation, and watch the strategy documents.

When other threats remain. A park saved from great dams still faced small ones. Keep the coalition alive and guard the park's legal status.

When the project is funded domestically. The financing lever won't reach it — lean harder on the EIA, the courts, protected-area status, the Bern Convention, and the public.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO'S CAPTURED

North Macedonia has real concerns about the capture of energy and construction projects, so this matters.

How to spot it. Permits against the evidence or inside a park; an EIA written for the proponent; consultation skipped; benefits to the connected while communities and the park bear the harm.

Who's supposed to guard against it. The **State Audit Office** and anti-corruption bodies examine public money and conduct. The **courts** can quash a tainted permit. The **banks' accountability mechanisms** expose safeguard breaches. And North Macedonia's **press and civil society** have exposed captured projects.

How to fight it safely. Document precisely and factually — the broken safeguard, the bent process, what the rules required — and keep clear the line between what you can prove and what you suspect. Route serious evidence to the audit and anti-corruption bodies, the banks' mechanisms, the courts, and trusted journalists rather than making accusations you can't back. Pair the exposure with the financing and treaty levers.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

Don't run these steps one after another — run them together. The money-and-rules documentation is the spearhead; the park and species aim it; a coalition of local roots and international expertise is the muscle; the bank complaints, the Bern Convention, the EIA, and the courts press the case; the international media raises the cost on the financiers. Together they multiply. One at a time, they stall — and press on to formal cancellation.

Early on (weeks 1–8): trace the financing and get the banks' safeguards; document the breaches; object at the EIA hearing; marshal the science; build a coalition with international networks.

In the thick of it (months–years): file the bank complaints; invoke the Bern Convention; challenge a defective permit; open the international media front.

The long haul (years): carry the complaints and litigation to the financiers' withdrawal — and then to formal cancellation; keep the coalition alive; guard the park's status and against remaining threats; hold the line for financing cut, a project killed, delay, and exposure.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Stopping a destructive project in North Macedonia can be done — a small organisation followed the money, held two development banks to their own rules, and killed two great dams in a national park, saving the last home of the Balkan lynx. Hold both truths. North Macedonia's distinctive power is real: when a project depends on international financing, cutting off that money — by holding the banks to their safeguard policies, invoking treaties like the Bern Convention, and drawing global attention — can turn the project's greatest strength into its fatal weakness. And the constraints are real: the plans can linger on paper after the money is cut, other threats remain, the strategy needs a project bound by international money and rules, and it takes a long, patient, expert campaign.

Here's the discipline that wins. Follow the money first: trace every loan to its bank, get the bank's safeguard policies, and document exactly where the project breaks them — then file the complaint, with precision. Invoke the Bern Convention for a protected species, and lean on national-park status. Take part in the EIA and challenge a defective permit. Bind your local roots to the international finance and conservation networks that know the banks from the inside, rally the science and the public around the park and its wildlife, and carry it to the world. Then press on past the financiers' withdrawal to formal cancellation, and guard against the threats that remain. Count financing cut, a project killed, a permit quashed, delay, and

exposure as wins. That's what Mavrovo did — following the money, and using the banks' own rules against them. So can you.